

Deserts

THE HOT, DRY DESERTS of the southwestern United States are home to a surprising variety of birds. To cope with the heat, birds rest in the shade of rocks or down burrows dug by desert mammals. There is not much water to drink—the Sonoran Desert receives less than 8 in (20 cm) of rain a year and the Great Basin deserts only 1½ in (4 cm) a year. Birds get most of the water they need from their food, such as seeds, other animals, and water-filled cacti. The spiny branches of cacti help protect the nests of many birds and some, such as the saguaro, are so big that birds can nest inside them, out of the heat of the sun. In the Great Basin Desert, the many sagebrush shrubs are rich in energy-giving fats for birds to eat.

Cactus wren

This is the largest North American wren. Like other wrens, it builds several nests—some to sleep in, some to shelter in, and a few for their eggs and young. Each nest is a domed shape with a tunnel-like entrance and is built on a prickly cholla cactus or a spiny yucca or mesquite tree. The wren doesn't seem to mind the sharp spines, but enemies find it hard to reach the nest.

Cactus wren
(*Campylorhynchus brunneicapillus*)
Length: 7½ in (19 cm)

Greater roadrunner

The roadrunner is really a type of cuckoo that lives on the ground. Even though it is often seen on roads, it is a shy bird that runs rapidly away from danger. It also chases anything that moves. On its long, powerful legs, it can sprint at up to 15 mph (24 kph), fluttering its stubby wings for extra speed. Its long tail acts as a brake to help the bird stop or change direction.

Greater roadrunner
(*Geococcyx californianus*)
Length: 2 ft (58 cm)

Elf owl

This is the smallest owl in the world—it is no bigger than an adult's hand. It feeds mainly at night, catching insects in its feet. It will also eat scorpions, taking out the sting or crushing it before starting to eat. To escape the heat of the sun, it roosts by day in holes in giant cacti dug by other birds. If captured, the elf owl pretends to be dead until it thinks the danger has passed.

Elf owl
(*Micrathene whitneyi*)
Length: 5½ in (14 cm)

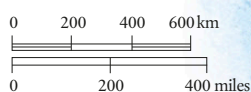
GULF OF ALASKA

NORTH AMERICA



A gila woodpecker perches on a giant desert cactus to feed insects to its young nesting inside.

PACIFIC OCEAN



	GOLDEN EAGLE		ELF OWL
	BLACK-BILLED MAGPIE		CACTUS WREN
	MOUNTAIN CHICKADEE		WHITE-TAILED PTARMIGAN
	GREATER ROADRUNNER		